

The Brother HL 5170DN and 5140 were joint second, with a cost of 87 paise per print out. The most expensive here was the Samsung 2250, which will set you back by nearly Rs 1.50 per print—more than twice as expensive as the Brother HL 6050D.

If you are looking at a printer that can output reams of prints at a reasonable speed and quality, printers such as the HL 6050D, will cut your printing costs down hugely and bring them to manageable levels. The printer will give you roughly 7,500 pages on a single toner. The toner cartridge, too, is not as expensive as those from rivals Samsung and WeP.

### Conclusion

Unlike the SoHo category, the winner here was quite clearly one of the Brothers as they had consistently outperformed or at least matched the rest of the pack. The question was, which one?

When the smoke cleared, we had our winner but it was the closest fight we have ever seen! The Brother HL 6050D won by less than a hair's breadth from the Brother HL-5140 to secure the *Digit* 'Best Buy Gold' Award. The Brother HL 5140 gets the *Digit* 'Best Buy Silver'. The competition was close enough to even warrant a tie.

If you need out and out performance and features and don't mind paying for it, the HL 6050D is the printer for you.

However, if you are budget conscious and don't mind trading in a few features and performance to save some money, you need not look beyond the HL5140.

The third Brother, the HL-5170, came in a



Brother HL 5140

close third, and definitely deserves a mention. This printer has great features, but average performance considering its price.

### COLOUR LASER PRINTERS

The printers in this category were every bit as big as the workgroup printers and would more than fulfil your colour requirements—unless you are looking for photo quality prints. That said, the photos we printed on regular paper came out rather well, making these printers an excellent buy if you need occasional working drafts of your designs or reference photos.

### Features

Even here, as was the case with mono lasers, the paper tray capacity varied between the Canon LBP 5200 that offered only a 125-page tray, Epson offering a 180-page tray and both, Samsung and Brother providing 250-page trays.

Canon again did not bundle any data cable, and Samsung, true to its style, bundled everything you could think of. Canon was also the only printer to support just one OS—Windows. Epson and Brother supported Windows and Mac, while the Samsung supported Windows and Linux!

Apart from the Canon 5200, which had no screen, all the others featured a monochrome display with simple menu functions configurable from the printer itself.

Only the Epson AcuLaser C1100 and Brother HL-2700CN were network-enabled. The Canon and Samsung CLP500 offered networking as an optional 'accessory'.

In terms of sheer build quality, none of the printers could hold a candle to the Brother 2700. A rock solid and extremely sturdy-looking printer.

The Samsung CLP500, though not flimsy overall, seemed as though some of its side trays or doors could break easily.

### Performance

If anyone knows how to make a printer warm-up quickly, it is Canon. The warm-up time of the LBP 5200 was a mere 4 seconds, as compared to the second-best time of 8 seconds by the Samsung CLP 500.

The Brother HL2700CN needed marginally

### Samsung SCX-5315F

The Samsung SCX-5315F was in a class of its own, and hence was not included in the comparison. It was priced much higher, at Rs 64,999, and was the only copier-based MFD we received. It had a black toner drum and cartridge system.

A maximum print resolution of 1200 x 1200 dpi was supported. The input tray could hold 550 sheets of paper, while the ADF tray could hold 30. The input paper capacity can be enhanced by adding an optional paper tray. It also has a side-sliding bypass tray to input special media, such as cards and labels. This MFD supported automatic duplex printing, and the monthly duty cycle of this printer was an impressive 18,750.

A scan resolution of 600 x 600 dpi at 24-bit colour is supported by the CCD scanner, for up to A4 size. A maximum of 999 copies in multi-copy mode is supported. At 21.3 kg and with a footprint of 43.4 x 45.9 cm, this is a heavy and large MFD.

There is an option to install an internal network card, and a 33.6 Kbps modem. There is also a special 'Toner Save' button that reduces the size of the printed dots and saves ink, in turn, reducing the cost per copy. It also has advanced features such as 'Clone' copy, which reduces the original document into a number of smaller copies on print media. There is also an 'Auto Fit' copy mode using which, the scanned document is automatically enlarged or reduced to fit the size of the media. Its 'Power Save' button saves power by putting the MFD into standby mode, and the 'Paper Save' button reduces two pages of a printout to fit on a single page.

In the printing speed test, though, this MFD scored just about average. But the quality was the best. In the scanning speed test, it was slower than every MFD that we tested and took 689.03 seconds to scan a photograph at 24-bit and 600 dpi—more than 50 per cent higher than the closest competitor. But the quality, again, was excellent and the colour differentiation, outstanding.

If you have an office with large volume of printing, this must be considered.

